



Akash was good enough to earn a training stint with NEROCA, one of Manipur's prominent football clubs that had played multiple seasons in the I-League, India's top tier of professional football at the time. He spent about a month with the club.

For a young player from a State that has produced generations of footballers, the attraction was obvious. He had more than a few friends who had gone down that path. Tondonba Singh, who hails from Akash's village, currently plays for NorthEast United. There was serious money to be made in football. There didn't seem to be much of a reward in sepak takraw.

But his father convinced him to stay. "He told me to play just one Asian Games. So I thought I'd play the 2014 Games and then I'll return to football," he says.

Akash did play at the 2014 Games in Incheon. But by the time they were over, he had changed his mind. He was only 19, and although he had already competed internationally, the scale of the Asian Games was different. He leaned heavily on the senior players around him. India did not medal.

The bronze at Jakarta-Palembang in 2018 felt different. It did more than change his sporting resume. "It changed the lives of everyone who played sepak takraw," he says.

Before that, playing sepak takraw did not necessarily mean financial security. Akash remembers a period when he had already represented India internationally but still had to work as a labourer, helping build houses to earn money while continuing to train. There were few facilities. A national medal did not

Airborne: Akash Yumnam in action against Iran during the Sepak Takraw Super Series in New Delhi on August 31, 2013. More than a decade later, he remains the senior statesman of India's sepak takraw team, preparing for his fourth Asian Games. SANDEEP SAXENA

automatically translate into a career.

He eventually joined the Sashastra Seema Bal, an official border-guarding organisation in India, and began to build a more stable life. The 2018 medal brought a promotion and greater recognition. Other players in the team got government jobs. "I've come from a time when there was nothing in the sport. Now there is a lot more opportunity to grow with the sport. I've seen it happen," he says.

In India, the game has changed in more ways than one. When Akash